



Dear friends and family,

In this newsletter, I want to share with you what life in Via over these last past three months has entailed. I'll try to touch on some of the gifts I have received, what I have learned, as well as some of the things that have been more challenging.

I believe the most important part of my formation in Via is prayer. Each weekday, we have silent prayer in the chapel at Saint Patrick's at 6:30AM; this is followed by morning mass at St. Patrick's or evening mass at Wisdom, depending on the schedule of our day. We pray liturgy of the hours every night and also have regular check-ins wherein the other Fellows and I get together to discuss specific virtues that need perfecting, vices that are causing us to struggle, or ways we might grow in our spiritual lives. We look out for one another and share with honesty and charity different ways we can improve, as well as ways that we have served one another well in our communal life, or not done so.

This year, I have had the privilege to work under Dr. John Anderson. Dr. Anderson is a radiation oncologist working in Lafayette and Opelousas. While working with Dr. John, I have seen what it looks like for a Catholic professional to use his gifts and intellect in his work. Dr. Anderson sees each patient as an individual person that deserves love and care. In his work he focuses on the well-being of others, and often over himself. My job is to scribe for him, which means I accompany him as he sees patients and document relevant things about the patient and his visit.



All of the Fellows of the 2023 cohort on the way up to Mt. Sneffels. Pictured are myself, Isaac, Andrew, Anthony, Rachel, and Ann-Ayrise.





On the Feast of the Nativity of Mary, we had friends over to make sushi. Anthony took the lead on preparation.



Isaac, Andrew, and I while insulating the Via House the night before our biggest event of the summer. We were up til about 1am to avoid renting the equipment for an additional day! While it was exhausting, we learned a lot and the house was significantly more comfortable for our guests.

This has allowed me to experience the medical field, improve my medical terminology, learn how to interact with patients and co-workers, and gain experience of what life as a doctor is like. I am grateful that Dr. Anderson gave me this opportunity and took time to help me learn and develop my understanding of medicine. I work for Dr. Anderson on Tuesdays and Thursdays, and on Wednesdays, I work with Saint Joseph's Handyman, under Sam Pitre and Brice Cambre. Both of these gentlemen exemplify how to live out Christ's teaching in their work. A few examples of this include the generous wages they offer employers (for which I am especially grateful), prayer at the start and end of work, the joy they maintain, and the charity they show to their customers. Through this highly hands-on job, I have gained skills such as painting, woodworking, using various tools, and getting experience in a whole new field of work. This has allowed me to expand my horizons of different career fields as my only interest thus far had been the medical field. This was such a gift as these life skills will carry over into the rest of my life. For example, Sam Pitre is currently using the skills he has gained to remodel his house without hiring outside help, and I would love to use this skill for my own home repair and renovation when I am older.

Another challenging yet rewarding aspect of life at Via is our morning routine. Each morning we get up at 6:00AM to pray. Then we eat a large breakfast together of toast, about 30 eggs, and lots of dishes to clean. Following breakfast on Tuesday and Thursday we go to work. In order to be on time, all of us must be intentional and focused with preparing, eating, and cleaning up during our morning routine.



Lebanese-themed dinner hosted by Father Cambre in his rectory at Saint Peter's in Carencro.

Each week we also host different events which include gatherings for feast days, “dinner and discussion,” “cigar night,” “game night,” “poetry night,” etc. I have particularly experienced the challenges in preparing for these events, but it is extremely rewarding to host so many people and has taught me a lot about community and hospitality. For example, we recently hosted a dinner and discussion on how to use money to glorify God and to make sense of Christ's invitation to poverty as a Catholic family. I learned a great deal from these discussions as I consider my life as a Catholic father and husband, and I believe the conversation significantly expanded my knowledge on those topics.

These gatherings are also opportunities to bring people in the community together for a formative experience, for example Hasan, a Muslim neighbor in grad school at University of Louisiana Lafayette, who came over during one of our gatherings, at first was shy and hesitant to come over, but after joining us for a few minutes he opened up in conversation and eventually really enjoyed himself. He asked some of us questions about our life, faith, country, and lifestyle. We also spoke to him about his lifestyle and how he viewed America. It was a true gift to have this experience.

We also have movie nights. At our last movie night, we watched *A Man for All Seasons*, a film about Saint Thomas More. This film really inspires one to strive to live out the virtues it takes to be a Saint. The particular virtues of More include courage, charity, loyalty and faith in God. While we watched the film, some of our other Muslim neighbors came over just to visit. It was clear that they were comfortable around us and showed me the joy a Christian household can bring to others. My old soccer coach and teacher Mr. Gray joined for the movie, as well as one of our neighbors Josh, whom we had met a couple of weeks earlier during our door-to-door outreach. We go door-to-door every couple of weeks and knock on our neighbors' doors throughout the street and introduce ourselves. More often than not, we pray with them. We do some kind of community outreach like this about each week. During our visit with Josh, he saw God's providential hand in us knocking on his door and just the night before the visit had resolved to quit his last drug, of which he had successfully been two weeks clean when he came over for the film.



Seminar with Fr. Guillory on the *Odyssey* at the Via House.



Summitting Mt. Sneffels at 14,155 ft.



Another event we host is cigar night. The purpose of these gatherings is to have community time with our friends and to have thoughtful, fruitful conversations. We also have other events just to hangout and celebrate feast days in the church. Throughout these last few months we eat at other people's houses who offer to host us. I have had the gift of getting to know many good people who I have learned many things from, such as cooking skills and just seeing how friends in our community live life as a family.

One of the major features of life in Via are the regular seminars. Every Monday, Wednesday and Friday, we have group discussions with all those in Via and the "tutor," who leads the discussion. We also have time set aside to read the content together out loud and to prepare for the seminar. Our first set of seminars took a deep look into the ancient Babylonian texts led by Luke Ungarino. We then followed this with the Ancient Israel sequence.

During the Ancient Israel sequence, we dove deep into scripture with the Old Testament led by Father John Joseph from the Community of Jesus Crucified. Deacon Conque led our seminars on the Old Testament prophets and how they exemplified the way in which we are to give our life to Christ and the Truth. Through these sequences we learned what it looks like to boldly proclaim the gospel as seen in the experiences of the prophets, and discovered the fruit that is borne when carefully reading Christ's word. Currently, we are diving deep into one of the most famous Greek texts, the *Odyssey*. Father Joshua Guillory, pastor at Saint Patrick's, is leading these seminars and teaching us how to find truth in this text. I find great fruit in doing close reads, tearing up each page in order to squeeze out all the knowledge we can, then discussing this with those who love and know many things about it.



From one of our hikes in Colorado

Taking these human experiences, learning from them, relating to them, and finding the truth in them, has helped me to understand how to live or how not to live in the world as a Christian. After every sequence, each Via fellow chooses a thesis to dive deeper into. For example, in the Ancient Israel sequence I presented on the theme of humility and its importance in one's relationship with God. There were many prophets and different scripture characters who humbled themselves in order to be brought up. Christ also humbled himself to be exalted and tells us to do the same. Because of how evident this was in the Old and New testament I decided to dive deeper into it. A variety of friends in the community came over to listen and discuss the topic which was both enlightening and motivating.

We have also attended two pilgrimages these last few months. Our first trip was to Ridgway, Colorado, where we spent about a week on a pilgrimage to the mountains. Here we took time to pray, relax in community, and hike a 14,155 foot mountain. This was an amazing gift and brought all of us closer together and to God in his creation. It also pushed me past my physical limits and challenged me in many ways. Waking up at 3am to climb a mountain, to get back around 7pm, hiking around 12 hours of that time, was a tremendously rewarding experience. Peter Fay, who was one of my highschool teachers and is currently on my formation team, led the fellows in the men's cohort of Via on another pilgrimage in Oklahoma. It was called the "Three Hearts Pilgrimage" which is done each year in Oklahoma. During this pilgrimage, we camped out and walked 35 miles to Clear Creek Abbey over two days. This was definitely a challenge, and forgetting all of our packed food in the car made it even harder, but it also forced us to rely on the radical generosity of others who fed us. This was a bit humiliating, but allowed us to suffer the consequences for our fault and recognize the generosity of others. This pilgrimage definitely taught me how to die to myself physically and give up my desire for comfort for a few days.



Jumping from the boat during the Fete Dieu de Teche; yes, I made it.



Making Taiwanese dumplings at Braxton and Libby Callens' house, with Every & All Missionaries.

The previous three months have been busy, challenging, and have pushed me in a way I haven't been before. But already I have gained so much from them and could not have had this chance without the support of countless people in the community. I want to especially thank my support team for their extreme generosity. Each of you has provided me with some of your hard earned money and blessed me with this formation that has formed me already in countless ways. I am forever grateful for your donations. I also want to thank my formation team for taking time to meet with me and help me grow as a man through your support and guidance. I want to thank my spiritual director, Father John Joseph, who has been a crucial help for me on my spiritual journey. Thank you sincerely for your prayers and I ask for continued prayers for myself and for the other Fellows, that we may be guided by the Holy Spirit in our formation and continue to grow in love of God and neighbor. Please let me know of any intentions you have that I can bring to prayer for you. It would be a gift to be able to pray for your intentions.

God Bless!

Sam

sam@studyworkpray.org